

Blog / 27 Jun 2026

Bangladesh's PM Discusses Teesta Project to China

Why in News?

Recently, Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, during his first official visit to China, sought Chinese support for the long-pending Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project.

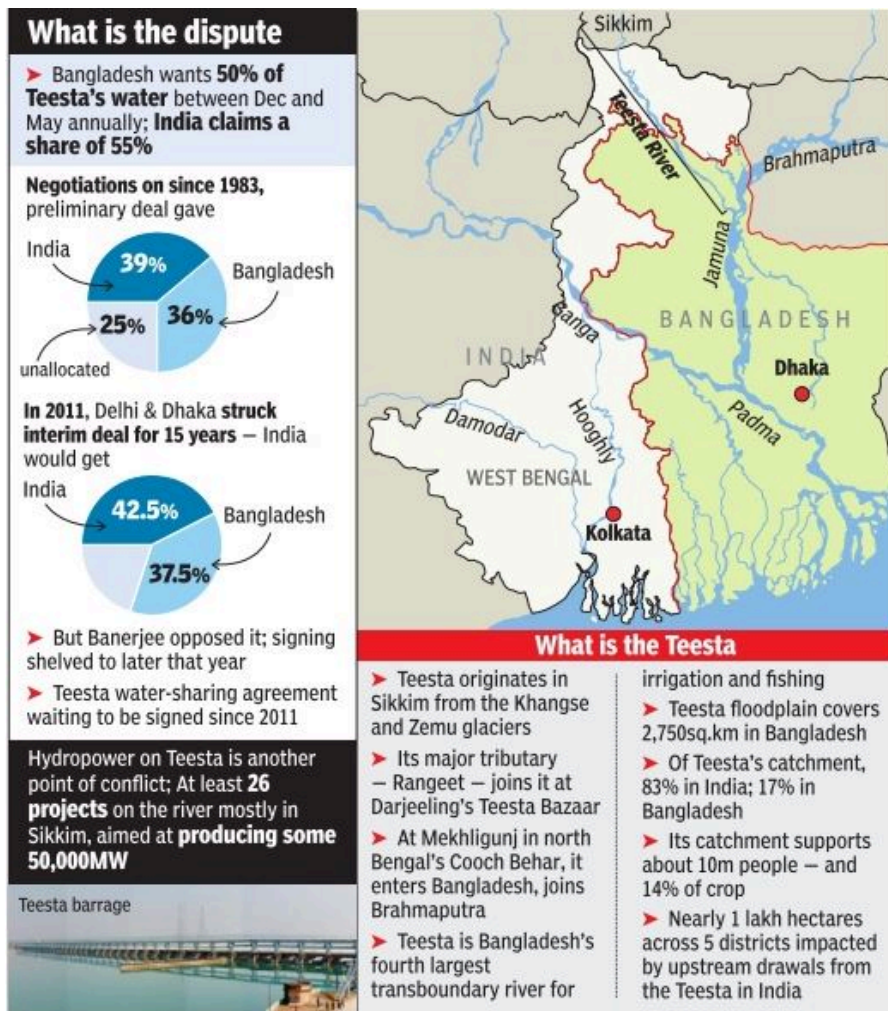
About Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project (TRCMRP):

The proposed project, estimated at nearly US\$1 billion, is being developed with Chinese technical assistance through POWERCHINA.

Major Components:

- River training and channel stabilization.
- Construction of about 114 km of embankments.
- Large-scale dredging of the river.
- Land reclamation using dredged materials.
- Flood control infrastructure.
- Irrigation expansion.
- Improvement of navigation.
- Restoration of degraded riverbanks.

The project also proposes narrowing the river from an average width of around 3 km to nearly 1 km by converting the naturally braided river into a controlled meandering channel.



Objectives of the Project:

The Bangladesh government expects the project to:

- Reduce riverbank erosion.
- Minimise flood damage.
- Increase irrigation coverage.
- Improve dry-season water availability.
- Enhance inland water transport.
- Reclaim approximately 170 sq. km of land.
- Promote regional economic development.

About The India-Bangladesh Teesta Water Dispute:

The Teesta is one of the most contentious transboundary rivers between India and Bangladesh.

Background

- Around 54 rivers are shared by India and Bangladesh.
- The Joint Rivers Commission (JRC) was established in 1972.
- A draft Teesta Water Sharing Agreement was negotiated in 2011.
- The agreement remains unsigned because of objections from the Government of West Bengal regarding water availability for farmers.

Bangladesh's Concerns

Bangladesh argues that:

- • Dry-season water availability has declined sharply.
- Water diversion at India's Gazaldoba Barrage has significantly reduced downstream flow.
- During the lean season, flows have reportedly fallen from nearly 10,000 cusecs in the 1990s to only a few
- Reduced discharge has affected agriculture, fisheries and livelihoods.

India's Concerns

India maintains that:

- • Water demands in North Bengal have increased.
- State government consent is necessary due to India's federal structure.
- River flow itself has declined because of climatic and hydrological changes.
- Chinese involvement near the strategically important Siliguri Corridor (Chicken's Neck) raises national security concerns.

Way Forward:

- • Conclude a fair and sustainable India-Bangladesh Teesta Water Sharing Agreement.
- Strengthen the Joint Rivers Commission.
- Adopt Integrated River Basin Management (IRBM).
- Ensure transparent environmental and social impact assessments.
- Increase stakeholder consultation with local communities and experts.
- Prioritise nature-based solutions over excessive structural interventions.
- Promote India-Bangladesh cooperation in flood forecasting, sediment management and climate
- Adaptation infrastructure projects are economically viable, environmentally sustainable and geopolitically balanced.

Conclusion:

The Teesta is no longer merely a river shared by India and Bangladesh, it has become a focal point where transboundary water governance, environmental sustainability, domestic politics and Indo-Pacific geopolitics converge. While Bangladesh seeks development through the Teesta restoration project with Chinese assistance, unresolved upstream water sharing, ecological concerns and strategic competition underscore the need for a cooperative, science-based and basin-wide approach. A durable solution lies not only in engineering interventions but also in equitable water diplomacy, ecological stewardship and sustained regional cooperation.